

Order Passeriformes continued

Family Callaeatidae

New Zealand wattlebirds

Length 10–15 in (25–38 cm)
Species 5



Wattlebirds, confined to New Zealand, are named for the orange or blue wattles at the base of their bill. They are short-winged, weak fliers but are adept at clambering and hopping about branches. The kokako and saddleback are the only living species. Surveys in the 1970s revealed that only tiny colonies of kokako remained in the North Island. Conservationists worked on plans to ensure its survival, which involved preservation of podocarp forests and control over the predation of its eggs and chicks. There are now around 30 separate populations of kokako, but it is still not out of danger. The other extant wattlebird is the saddleback (shown right). The huia, *Heterolocha acutirostris*, last seen

in 1907, was unique in that the sexes had different bill shapes: the male had a straight, pointed bill, while the female had a thin, downcurved one. The huia became extinct due to habitat destruction and being hunted for its feathers.



SOUTH ISLAND SADDLEBACK
AA weak flier, Philesturnus carunculatus—which is 10 in (25 cm) long—runs and hops through trees, probing the bark for insects. It nests on remote islands and is seldom seen. A small population has recently been introduced to an island in Auckland Harbour where visitor numbers are regulated.

Family Vangidae

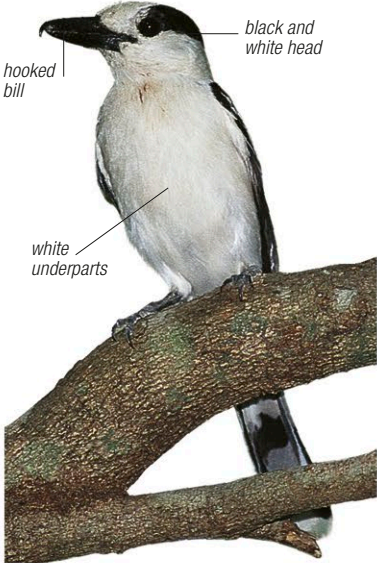
Vangas

Length 4¾–12 in (12–30 cm)
Species 21



Vangas are restricted to Madagascar (with the blue vanga also found in the Comoro Islands), but it is possible that other African shrikes belong in this family. All are tree-living birds, some being confined to the evergreen forest in the humid east, while others extend into wooded areas in the western savanna, and some even occur in semidesert scrub. Many of them are boldly patterned in black and white, and have a heavy bill, often hooked at the tip. Although they usually eat insects, some

may also feed on treefrogs and small reptiles. They often form loose feeding flocks, sometimes with other species. Some species build a cup of twigs in a tree and lay 3–4 eggs; both parents raise the young.



hooked bill
black and white head
white underparts

HOOK-BILLED VANGA
A solitary bird, Vanga curvirostris is 10–11½ in (25–29 cm) long, and has a heavy, hooked bill. It lives in evergreen forest, brush, plantations, and mangroves across Madagascar.

Family Malaconotidae

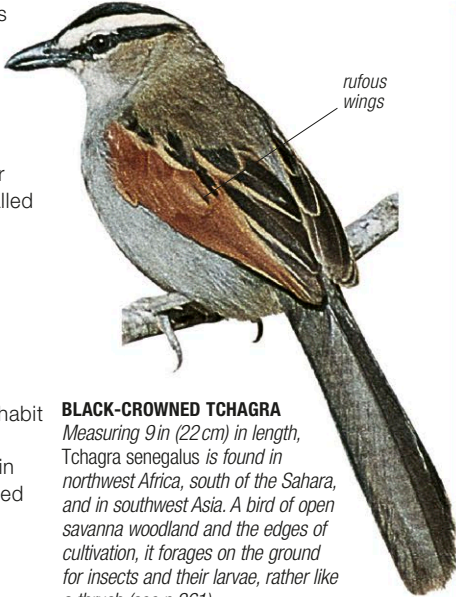
Bushshrikes and relatives

Length 6–12 in (15–30 cm)
Species 49



Confined to Africa, bush shrikes are closely allied to the vangas of Madagascar, and some—such as the crested helmet-shrikes—may be genetically closer to vangas. Although many are shy, retiring birds—they are generally more brightly colored than birds of the true shrike family—Laniidae—in which they were

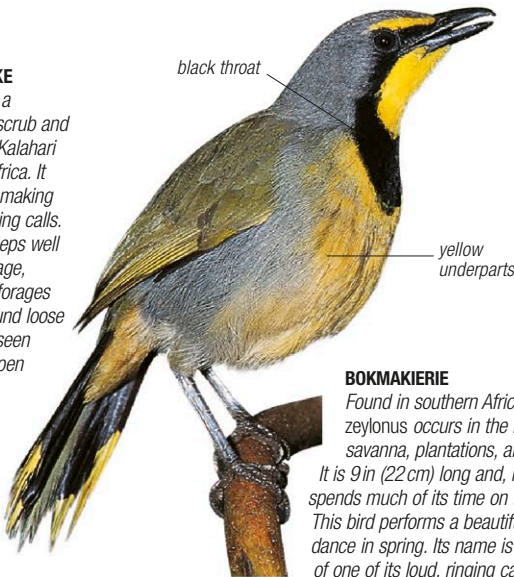
previously classified. Some, such as helmet-shrikes, travel in noisy groups, and all have distinctive loud calls that are often delivered from a prominent perch. Tchagras are more somberly colored thicket-dwellers, but have distinctive darker head patterns. Puffbacks are so-called because of the fact they puff out loose feathers on their back during display: displaying males look like fluffy balls. Members of the family occur in forest or dry thorny scrub, where they prey on insects; larger species can also tackle frogs and snakes. They lack the true shrike's habit of impaling victims on thorns and spikes, and tend to be more active in pursuit of prey. Nests are cup-shaped affairs in bushes or trees.



rufous wings
BLACK-CROWNED TCHAGRA
Measuring 9 in (22 cm) in length, Tchagra senegalus is found in northwest Africa, south of the Sahara, and in southwest Asia. A bird of open savanna woodland and the edges of cultivation, it forages on the ground for insects and their larvae, rather like a thrush (see p.361).



CRIMSON-BREASTED SHRIKE
Laniarius atrococcineus is a common bird of thorny scrub and acacia thickets in the Kalahari region of southern Africa. It is frequently heard making loud, hollow, whistling calls. While not shy, it keeps well hidden in thick foliage, jerking its tail as it forages for large insects around loose bark. It is more easily seen when taking ants from open spaces on the ground.



black throat
yellow underparts
BOKMAKIERIE
Found in southern Africa, Telephorus zeylonus occurs in the bush, open savanna, plantations, and gardens. It is 9 in (22 cm) long and, like a thrush, spends much of its time on the ground. This bird performs a beautiful courtship dance in spring. Its name is a transcription of one of its loud, ringing calls.

Family Artamidae

Woodswallows

Length 12–20 cm (4¾–8 in)
Species 24



Woodswallows occur in parts of Asia, the Pacific Islands, New Guinea, and Australia. Despite the family name, these birds are not closely related to the swallow family, although their flight silhouette is similar to that of martins. Unusually for passerines, they often soar on the wing. They are 12–20 cm (4¾–8 in) long, and have strong bills and short legs and feet, while the wings are quite short and pointed. A characteristic family trait is the birds' habit of huddling together on branches, particularly when roosting. These insectivorous birds catch much of their prey on the wing. They are gregarious and build their grassy, cup-like nests on stumps, in holes or in bushes. All members of the family are colonial nesters. Females lay 2–4 white or cream eggs, with red-brown spots.



black mask
BLACK-FACED WOODSWALLOW
Distributed across Australia, New Guinea, the Lesser Sundas, and Timor, Artamus cinereus—measuring 19 cm (7½ in) in length—is the commonest bird in the family. Unlike other woodswallows, it is not very nomadic.